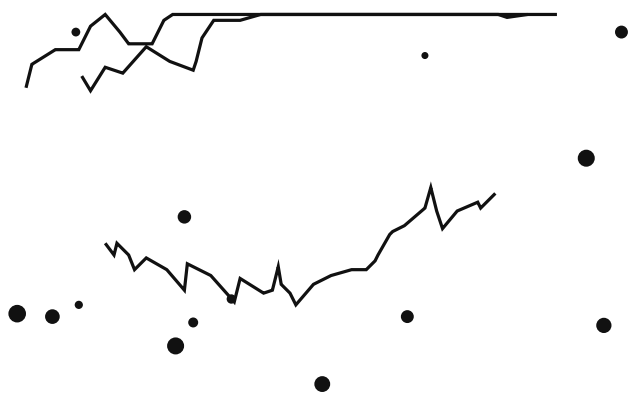


Papier Bleu



No. 49

JANUARY 2019

PROSE POETRY

Papier Bleu

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Ten writers on the second language

MASTHEAD

Founder & Editor-in-Chief

Kristil Rabideau

Papier Bleu is an independent student magazine. It is not an official publication of Uppsala University, and the views expressed belong to the writers.

Contributors are listed on pages 17 and 18.

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INTERESTED IN SUBMITTING?

Send works no longer than 500 words, in the form of prose poetry. If you are looking for clarity, the best example is Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities*, or this issue.

Send your work to rabideaukristil@gmail.com.

Please title your email "Papier Bleu Submission" for easy finding.

A SMALL DICTIONARY OF YLVERNA

Tove E. · Uppsala Univ.

Ylverna has one word where other cities have a hundred, and a hundred words where other cities have none.

LAGOM (adj.) Not too much, not too little. Used of soup, of grief, and of the distance between strangers at a bus stop. It cannot be translated; it can only be stood beside.

FIKA (n., v.) A pause with cake in it. In Ylverna it is also a treaty. No quarrel has survived the second cup.

MYS (n.) The warmth that arrives when the lamps are lit and the snow begins. Visitors are advised not to look for its source.

SAKNA (v.) To miss someone; literally, to feel the lack of. In Ylverna the verb is conjugated by the empty chair.

ORD (n.) A word. The city keeps one empty, for the word you will learn last.

Visitors learn the dictionary in a winter. They leave in spring, fluent, and are not understood at home.

FOUR HOURS OF DAYLIGHT

Astrid J. · Uppsala Univ.

UPPSALA, JANUARY 3. SUNRISE 8:46. SUNSET 14:56.

8:46 The light arrives like a guest who has been told to be quiet.

10:00 Windows are opened to check that it is there.

12:00 Noon. The sun stands at the height of a child's hand, and the whole city holds up its coffee to it.

13:30 The shadows are longer than the people who cast them.

14:30 Lamps are lit in the library, out of politeness.

14:56 Gone.

15:00

16:00

17:00 Someone is still reading by the memory of it.

18:00

19:00

The day is not short. It is only quick, like a rumor.

THE VISITORS' LANGUAGE

Saga N. · Stockholm Univ.

In the city of Hallund no one speaks the language of Hallund. The citizens speak the languages they were born into, in their kitchens, in their sleep, to their dogs. The language of the city is spoken only by visitors, who learn it from one another on the night train and arrive already fluent in a tongue no one has ever heard.

At the market the vendors and the visitors conduct their business without a single word in common. The visitor says the word for bread as he believes it to be; the vendor hears the word for bread as she believes it to be; both are right, and bread is exchanged.

The council has often proposed teaching Hallund to its children. The visitors object. A language that is taught, they say, begins to be wrong, and the city's only fluency is its mistakes.

So the children grow up and become visitors in their own streets, learning Hallund from strangers, with an accent. In this way no one is ever from there, and everyone is home.

PHRASEBOOK FOR A COUNTRY ALMOST LEARNED

Wilma U. · Stockholm Univ.

Useful expressions. Read the left-hand column aloud; keep the right to yourself.

SAY Excuse me, where is the station?

MEAN Where did you go?

SAY Thank you, no, I'm fine.

MEAN I am not fine; ask again.

SAY What a nice day!

MEAN I have run out of other subjects.

SAY I'm sorry, I don't understand.

MEAN I understand, and wish I did not.

SAY Do you live here?

MEAN Will you let me?

SAY See you soon.

MEAN The weather will decide.

The country is small and has no border. You are in it as soon as you stop translating, and out of it the moment you notice.

LAST WILL OF A BILINGUAL HOUSE

Nils U. · Stockholm Univ.

I, the house at the end of the street, being of sound foundation and uncertain mind, leave the following:

1. To my first tenant, the word for snow that she learned from my roof.
2. To my second, the staircase, which has been practicing silence for forty winters.
3. To the girl who left a window open in July, the draught. She knows what it means.
4. To the two languages that lived in the kitchen and the hall: each other.
5. To the stranger who arrives last, the key, which fits both doors and neither lock.

Signed in two languages, neither of them legally binding. Witnessed by the stairs.

TELEPHONE BETWEEN TWO HARBORS

Ingrid U. · Lund Univ.

*Each line was carried to the next harbor by someone
who understood only half of it.*

The harbor keeps its boats the way a mother keeps a
name.

The harbor holds its ships the way a mother holds a
word.

The port keeps its vessels as a mother keeps a
sound.

The port stores its ships like a mother stores a
noise.

The port parks its ships like a mother parks a
noise.

A garage for noises, where mothers wait.

THE THREE WHO LIVE PAST Z

Maja A. · Uppsala Univ.

The alphabet of the northern city ends not at Z, where the map says, but three streets further, outside the gate, where Å, Ä and Ö keep house.

Å lives by the water and says only the sound of a river. Ä lives under the bridge and says the sound of a question asked in a warm room. Ö lives alone on the island and says what the sea says, which is o.

Visitors who have heard them say they are the only part of the language that sounds like a place. The citizens have never gone beyond Z. But every so often a child wakes at night and says one of the three in her sleep, and the whole street turns over in bed.

Å means a small river. Ö means an island. Ä means nothing at all; it is the sound a person makes on seeing a door open.

CUSTOMS OF THE SECOND LANGUAGE

Freja S. · Lund Univ.

BORDER OF THE SECOND LANGUAGE. DECLARATION.

Name: (as pronounced here)

Purpose of visit: To be understood. To be misunderstood less.

Length of stay: Until I dream in it.

Anything to declare? One lullaby, in poor repair. Several hundred words I do not need. A joke that does not cross.

Are you carrying food? The word for the soup my grandmother made, packed at the bottom of my chest.

Contact with native speakers? Yes, though briefly, and at a distance.

Signature: _____

The officer will return it in a different hand.

LEGEND FOR A MAP WITHOUT ITS MAP

Emil B. · Lund Univ.

The map has been lost. The legend remains, and is read by those who have forgotten where they were going.

- (o) a house where my name was said correctly
- (+) a bench that has heard the whole story
- (~) a river crossed in order to be forgiven
- (x) the place you were sure of
- (=) a bridge between two sentences
- (.) you are here, but not for long

Those who follow the legend arrive, eventually, where all the symbols agree. It is unmarked and very small.

COUNTING RHYME

Ebba A. · Lund Univ.

Ett. One: a door left open.

Två. Two: a voice and its echo.

Tre. Three: a table with one chair too many.

Fyra. Four: windows facing the same dark.

Fem. Five: the hand with the whole winter in it.

Sex. Six: a word that means something else in English. Smile, and move on.

Sju. Seven: the days, and the bridge between them.

Åtta. Eight: a number that cannot be unfolded.

Nio. Nine: nearly there.

Tio. Ten: and you have forgotten the first, and must begin again.

CONTRIBUTORS

Tove E. (Uppsala Univ.) studies linguistics in Uppsala and keeps a notebook of words that have no English.

Astrid J. (Uppsala Univ.) is a physics student who measures winter in minutes of daylight.

Saga N. (Stockholm Univ.) writes on the night train between Stockholm and Uppsala.

Wilma U. (Stockholm Univ.) teaches English to her grandmother and learns Swedish again.

Nils U. (Stockholm Univ.) is studying law and writing in his third language.

Ingrid U. (Lund Univ.) studies translation and has a weakness for mistakes.

Maja A. (Uppsala Univ.) is a first-year, and fond of the last letters of the alphabet.

Freja S. (Lund Univ.) studies in Lund and has never declared anything at a border.

Emil B. (Lund Univ.) makes maps, mostly of places he has not been.

Ebba A. (Lund Univ.) sings, counts, and is learning to do neither in English.

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